THE PROMISE OF THE POLITICAL

Where else can we find evidence for the promise of the political in today's Myanmar? The findings of Bridget Welsh and Kai-Ping Huang (2016) perhaps hint at it. Drawing on data from the first-ever Asian Barometer Survey conducted in Myanmar, Welsh and Huang observe that while people there have clearly had enough of violence as a response to conflict, they retain strongly conflicting political values. The survey's respondents appear to reject the nonpolitical responses to conflict of days gone by, while embracing the promise of the political through precisely the type of nonconsensual activity that it entails.[7]

Other writers for *Conflict in Myanmar* go looking for the promise of the political in particular places, and among distinct communities. Gerard McCarthy (2016) goes in search of an emerging "inchoate politics of the daily" (Prasse-Freeman 2012), in the provincial town of Taungoo. Amid rubbish clean ups and funeral services, he identifies a notion of citizenship that has echoes of the moral narrative on democracy about which Wells writes. McCarthy's "political" reveals itself through ostensibly apolitical informal practices of welfare and religious networks. These practices together constitute the means whereby, after decades of nonpolitical behaviour, the political can be excavated and recovered. McCarthy maps political activities across a range of institutions and projects, large and small, and explores the intersections between charity and the reemergence of political parties, as well as advocacy groups. He concludes that the political is expressed in a variety of different forms, which have in common low expectations of the state as a service provider, as well as a deeply religious and specifically Buddhist morality (see also Than Tun 2016).

The problem here, in my view, is that political ideas and practices lead to nonpolitical cul-de-sacs. Absent of Buddhist morality, the non-Buddhist lacks the necessary qualities to act politically. An authentic political relationship with the non-Buddhist becomes impossible. And so rather than being political, this form of morality is potentially corrosive of it. Insofar as the political is reformulated in moral terms of good (us) versus evil (them) the possibility of political engagement is denied.

Two chapters gesture to the political in their discussions of civil war in Kachin State. Costas Laoutides and Anthony Ware (2016) critically reexamine premises that the war is "ethnic" in character. While recognizing that actors and analysts tend to use the language of ethnicity and